

Technology	Scalability	Setup Complexity	Operational Overhead	Cost Model
Kubernetes	High	High	High	Primarily pay-per-node/infrastructure; Kubernetes itself is open source
Docker Swarm	Medium	Low	Low	Primarily pay-per-node/infrastructure; Swarm itself is open source
AWS Fargate	High	Low–Medium	Low	Pay-per-use (vCPU, memory, and related resources consumed)

Executive Summary

Kubernetes, Docker Swarm, and AWS Fargate provide different approaches to running containerized workloads. Kubernetes offers high scalability and extensive customization, but its broader capabilities come with higher setup complexity and operational overhead. Docker Swarm provides a simpler orchestration experience with lower operational demands, but it offers a smaller feature set and less flexibility for complex growth scenarios. AWS Fargate abstracts much of the underlying infrastructure management, providing high scalability with relatively low operational overhead and a usage-based cost model.

For a fast-growing startup that prioritizes **speed over infrastructure scaling**, **AWS Fargate** is the most suitable choice based on these criteria. Its managed, serverless container model reduces infrastructure-management responsibilities and can allow development teams to focus more heavily on application delivery. Kubernetes may become more relevant if the startup later requires extensive orchestration control or complex infrastructure customization, while Docker Swarm emphasizes simplicity. The appropriate choice ultimately depends on the startup's AWS dependence, workload characteristics, and expected operational requirements.